

# Emails That Get Replies

Copy-paste templates for asking, following up, negotiating, and saying no at work.

# Before we start

Most unanswered emails aren't ignored on purpose — they're just unclear about what they want or too much effort to respond to. Every template here follows the same rule: one ask, stated early, with the easiest possible way to say yes. Adjust the tone to match your workplace, but keep the structure.

## 1. The anatomy of an email that gets replied to

| Part         | Rule                                                                                                   |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Subject line | State the ask or topic directly. "Quick question on Q3 budget" beats "Hi" or "Following up."           |
| First line   | Get to the point in the first sentence. Context, if needed, comes after — not before.                  |
| The ask      | One clear ask per email. Multiple asks make it easy to reply to only the easy one and forget the rest. |
| The close    | Make the next step obvious — a specific question, a proposed time, a yes/no decision.                  |

**Rule of thumb:** if the recipient has to re-read your email to figure out what you want, most people will just leave it for "later" — which often means never.

## 2. Asking for something

### Asking for information or help

*Subject: Quick input needed on [topic] by [date]*

Hi [Name],

I'm working on [brief context, one line]. Could you share [specific thing you need] by [date]?

If it's easier to talk it through, I'm free [time option] — happy to work around your schedule.

Thanks,

[Your name]

### Asking for a deadline extension

*Subject: Requesting a short extension on [task]*

Hi [Name],

I want to flag early rather than at the last minute — [task] is going to need [X extra days] beyond [original deadline] because [one-line honest reason].

I can have it to you by [new date]. Let me know if that works, or if there's a way I can prioritise differently to hit the original date.

Thanks for understanding,

[Your name]

## 3. Following up without being annoying

### First follow-up (after ~3-5 working days of silence)

*Subject: Re: [original subject]*

Hi [Name],

Just bumping this up in case it got buried — no rush, but wanted to check if you had a chance to look at it.

[Your name]

### Second follow-up (if still no response)

*Subject: Re: [original subject] — checking in once more*

Hi [Name],

Following up once more on this — if now isn't a good time, let me know and I can check back [specific later date], or loop in [alternative person] if that's easier.

[Your name]

**The pattern:** each follow-up gives an easy out ("no rush", "let me know if now isn't a good time") while still making it clear you're expecting a response. Never send a third follow-up with the same tone — either escalate to a call, or genuinely let it go.

## 4. Negotiating

### Asking for a raise

*Subject: Time to discuss my compensation*

Hi [Manager's name],

I'd like to set up some time to discuss my compensation. Over the past [timeframe], I've [1-2 concrete outcomes — a project shipped, a metric improved, scope taken on].

Could we find 20-30 minutes this week or next to talk through this?

Thanks,  
[Your name]

### Countering an offer

*Subject: Re: Offer for [role]*

Hi [Name],

Thank you for the offer — I'm genuinely excited about the role. Based on [market research / my current comp / scope of the role], I was hoping we could look at [specific number or range] for the base, alongside the rest of the package as proposed.

Happy to jump on a call if that's easier to discuss.

Best,  
[Your name]

## 5. Saying no

### Declining a request politely

*Subject: Re: [request]*

Hi [Name],

Thanks for thinking of me for this. I won't be able to take this on given [one-line honest reason — current workload, timeline conflict, out of scope].

[Optional: Would [alternative person] be a good fit, or could this wait until [date]?]

[Your name]

## **Declining a meeting that doesn't need you**

*Subject: Re: [meeting invite]*

Hi [Name],

I don't think I'll add much value to this one given [reason] — happy to review notes or async input afterward if useful. Let me know if you'd still like me there for a specific reason.

[Your name]

## 6. Mistakes that quietly kill response rates

- **Burying the ask in paragraph three.** If it's not in the first two lines, half your readers won't get that far.
- **Multiple asks in one email.** Split them, or number them clearly — a wall of text with 3 questions usually gets 1 answered.
- **Vague subject lines.** "Hi" or "Question" gives no reason to open it before the urgent-looking ones.
- **No specific next step.** "Let me know your thoughts" is weaker than "Does Thursday at 3pm work?" — specificity is easier to respond to than open-endedness.
- **Over-apologising.** A follow-up doesn't need three sentences of "sorry to bother you" — one polite line is enough.

## 7. Quick answers to common questions

### How long should I wait before the first follow-up?

3-5 working days for most internal requests; sooner (1-2 days) for anything genuinely time-sensitive, and say so explicitly in the original email.

### Should I CC someone to add pressure?

Only if there's a genuine reason they need visibility — using CC purely as pressure usually damages the relationship more than it speeds up the response.

### Is it okay to follow up over chat instead of email?

Yes, especially internally — match the follow-up channel to wherever your team actually communicates fastest, which isn't always email.

## 8. Before you hit send

- ✓ Is the ask in the first two lines?
- ✓ Is there exactly one ask, not three?
- ✓ Does the subject line describe the actual topic?
- ✓ Is the next step specific (a date, a yes/no, a time) rather than open-ended?
- ✓ Would you understand what's needed if you only skimmed this on your phone?

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These templates are starting points — adjust tone and formality to match your workplace culture and your relationship with the recipient.